handsomest. He said, ‘Yes, they are pretty; but I have got some more that are handsomer, and I will send them this evening, and you had better keep the ones you like best.’ I expressed my gratitude for such unbounded liberality; his answer was: ‘I have plenty more.’ He then led the subject to horses.[116]

Nor did Lord Auckland’s proclivities escape Ranjit’s scrutiny:

‘Is Lord Auckland married?’

‘No.’

‘What! Has he no wives at all?’

‘None.’

‘Why doesn’t he marry?’

‘I don’t know.’

‘Why don’t you marry?’

‘I can’t afford it.’

‘Why not? Are English wives very expensive?’

‘Yes; very.’

‘I wanted one myself some time ago and wrote to the government about it, but they did not send me one.’[117]

Such banter was partly a smokescreen to disarm the British and disguise from them the acute political intelligence Ranjit Singh always displayed in negotiation. This was something Osborne was perceptive enough to recognise: ‘Ill-looking as he undoubtedly is, the countenance of Runjeet Singh cannot fail to strike everyone as that of a very extraordinary man . . . so much intelligence, and the restless wandering of his single fiery eye excites so much interest, that you are forced to confess that there is no common degree of intellect and acuteness developed in his countenance, however odd his first appearance may be.’

Ranjit Singh’s negotiating skills soon made themselves apparent and before long the wily Sikh leader was running rings around the uptight Macnaghten. One colleague wrote that ‘poor Macnaghten should never have left the secretary’s office. He is ignorant of men, even to simplicity, and utterly incapable of forming and guiding administrative measures. The judicial line would probably have best suited him, and even then only in the court of appeal, judging only written evidence.’[118]

Auckland had not initially thought of committing British troops to the project of unseating Dost Mohammad: the fighting he hoped was all to be done by Ranjit Singh and Shah Shuja, and, as on Shuja’s last expedition, the British would provide only money, equipment and moral and diplomatic